



Northwest South America

HIGH MOUNTAINS AND PLATEAUS, dense tropical rainforest, and coastal swamps are found in this region. In the 16th century, promises of untold riches attracted the Spanish to the countries here. They found the vast empire of the Incas, which stretched from what is now Peru into northern Colombia. To the north and east, other colonizers—Dutch, English, and French—arrived. Today, although the countries are independent, with the exception of French Guiana, Spanish remains the main language. The population is mainly a mix of native peoples and Europeans, except along the Caribbean coast where descendants of former African slaves live.



ANDES MOUNTAINS

The Andes, the world's longest mountain chain, extends 4,505 miles (7,250 km) down the western edge of South America. Barley, wheat, and potatoes grow well in highland areas, and are cultivated on the terraced hillsides.



FRENCH GUIANA

French Guiana is the only remaining colony in South America, and is governed by France. Tropical forests cover more than four-fifths of its land. In 1968, the European Space Agency established a launch site on the coast at Kourou, which is still used today.

CARACAS

Venezuela's population is growing rapidly and more than 89 per cent of its people now live in cities. The oil industry brings in considerable wealth, but many people are still poor. Although Caracas, Venezuela's capital city, is an important financial center, it has many shantytowns.